UK Medicine Trade

Trend Analysis, 2022–2026

A briefing on UK medicine exports and imports, from HMRC customs data.



Emanuel Cunha, Data Analyst

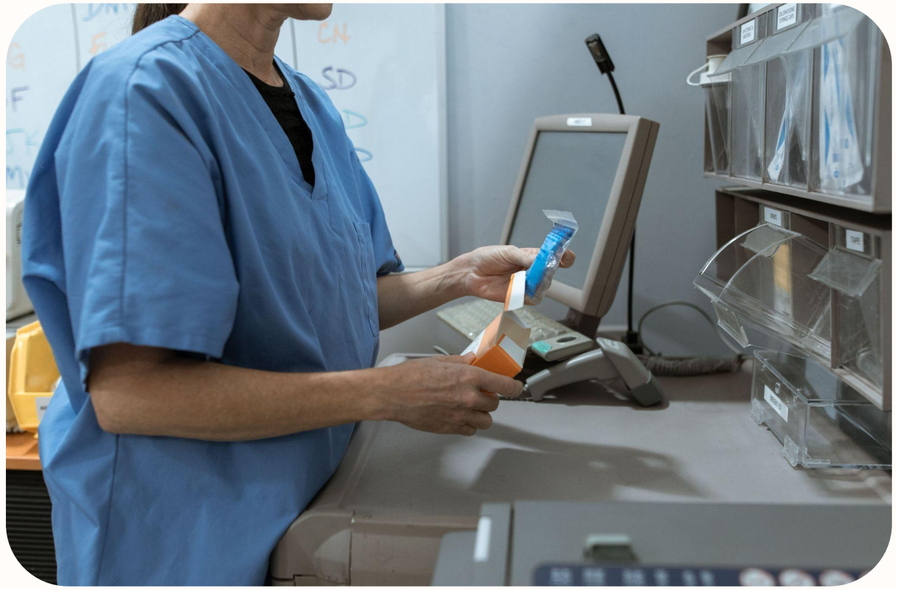
Data to July 2026

Agenda

1. Business task and data (2 min)
2. The short answer (1 min)
3. Exports, imports and the gap (2 min)
4. Buyers and suppliers (2 min)
5. Product groups and value per kg (2 min)
6. Limitations (1 min)
7. Recommendations (1 min)
8. Explore the dashboard (1 min)







Business task

1 Selling more or fewer medicines abroad?

2 Who is buying?

3 Leaning more on imports?

Data and method

Contains public sector information licensed under the
Open Government Licence v3.0.

Source
HMRC customs records, medicines only

Period
Jan 2022 to Jul 2026

Measures
Value (£), with weight (kg) as a check

Method
12-month averages smooth monthly swings

The short answer

UK medicine exports are worth less than in 2022, and imports now outweigh them.

£1,703m

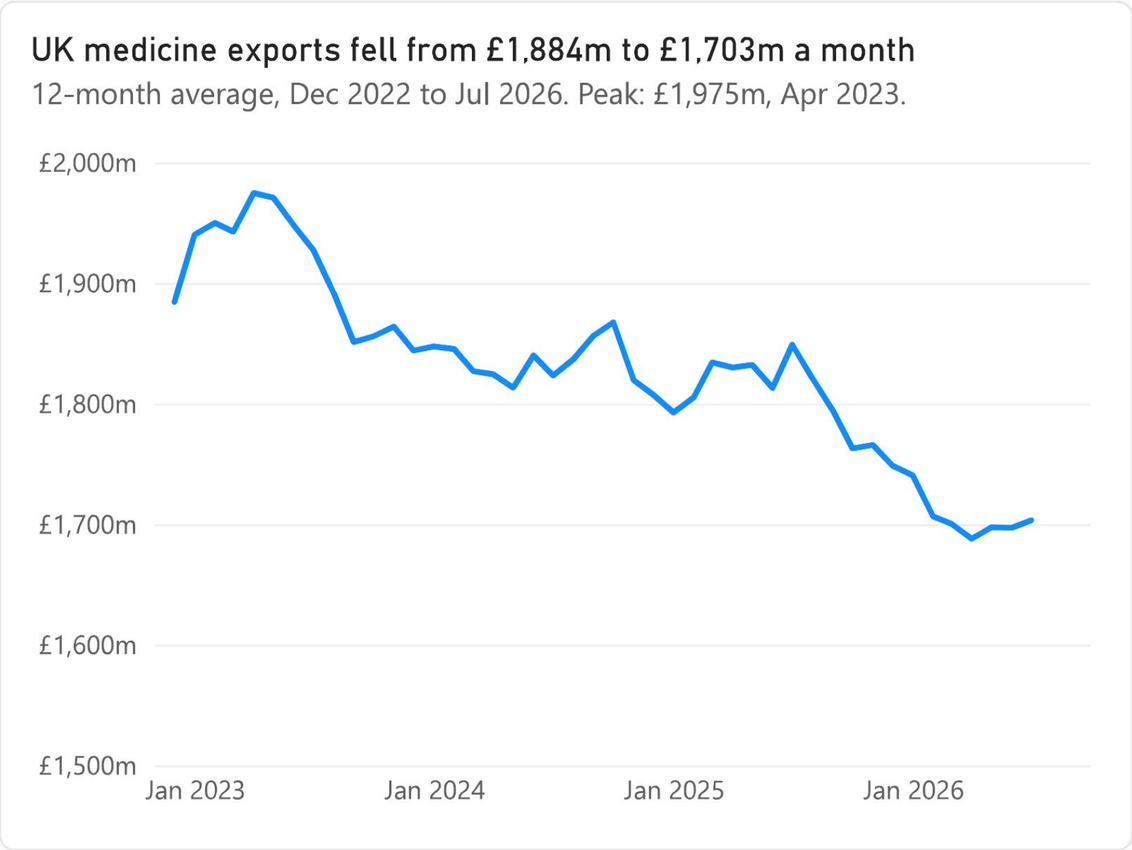
Exports a month, down from £1,884m in 2022

47%

of exports since 2022 went to the US, Belgium and Germany

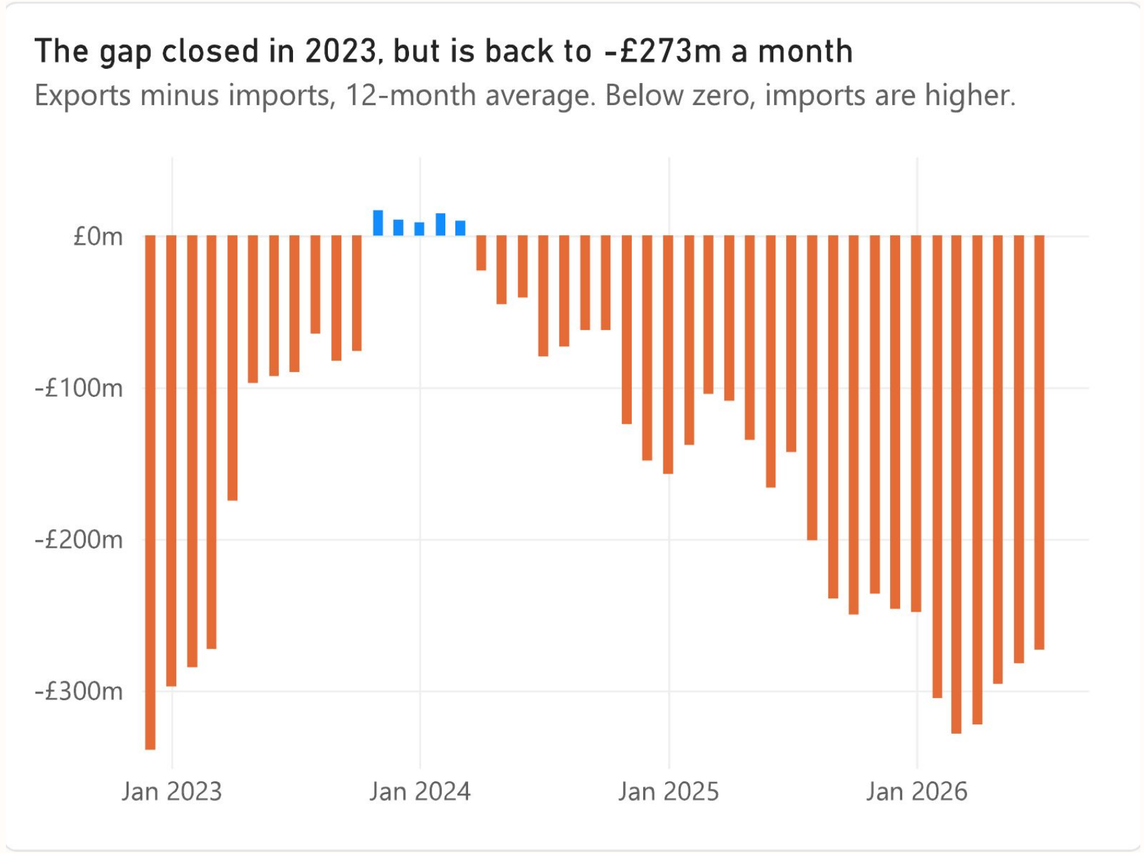
-£273m

Monthly gap: imports ahead of exports



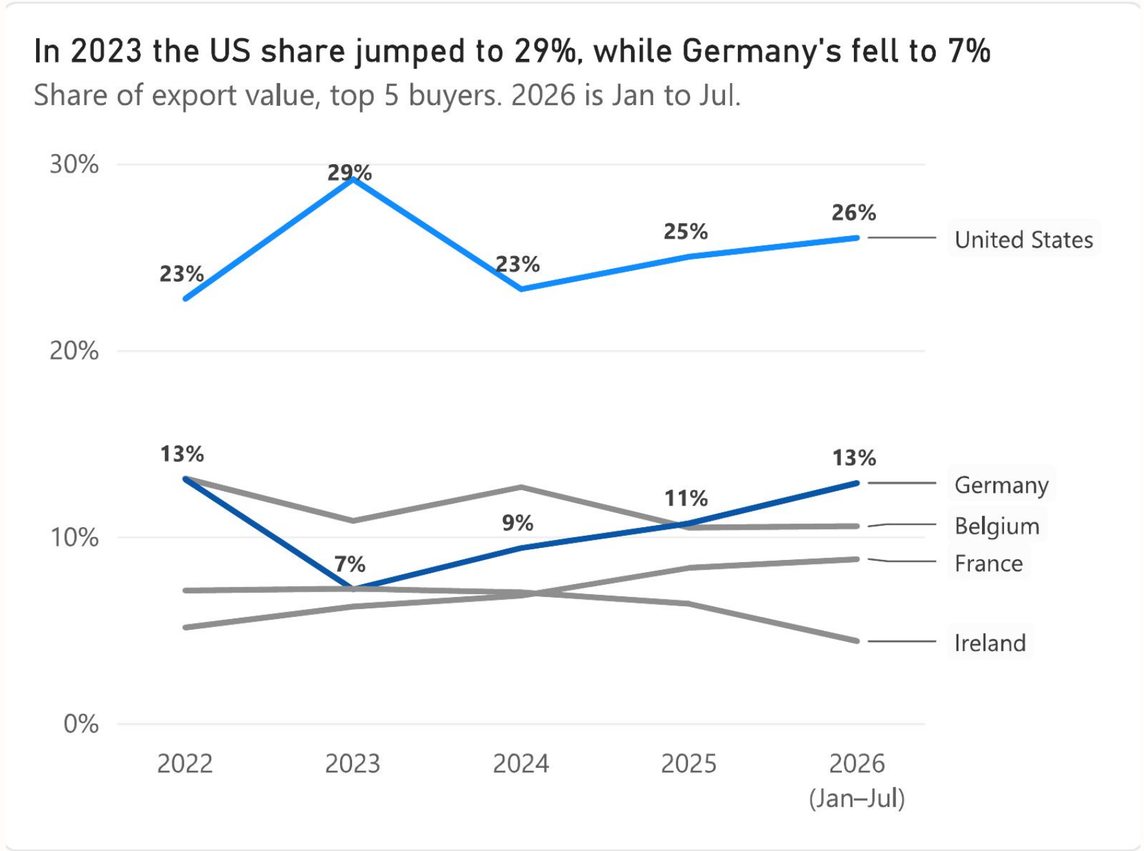
The trend

- The fall is not a one-off: each full year has averaged less than the one before.
- Each point is a 12-month average, so one unusual month barely moves the line.
- The line starts in December 2022, the first month with a full year of data.



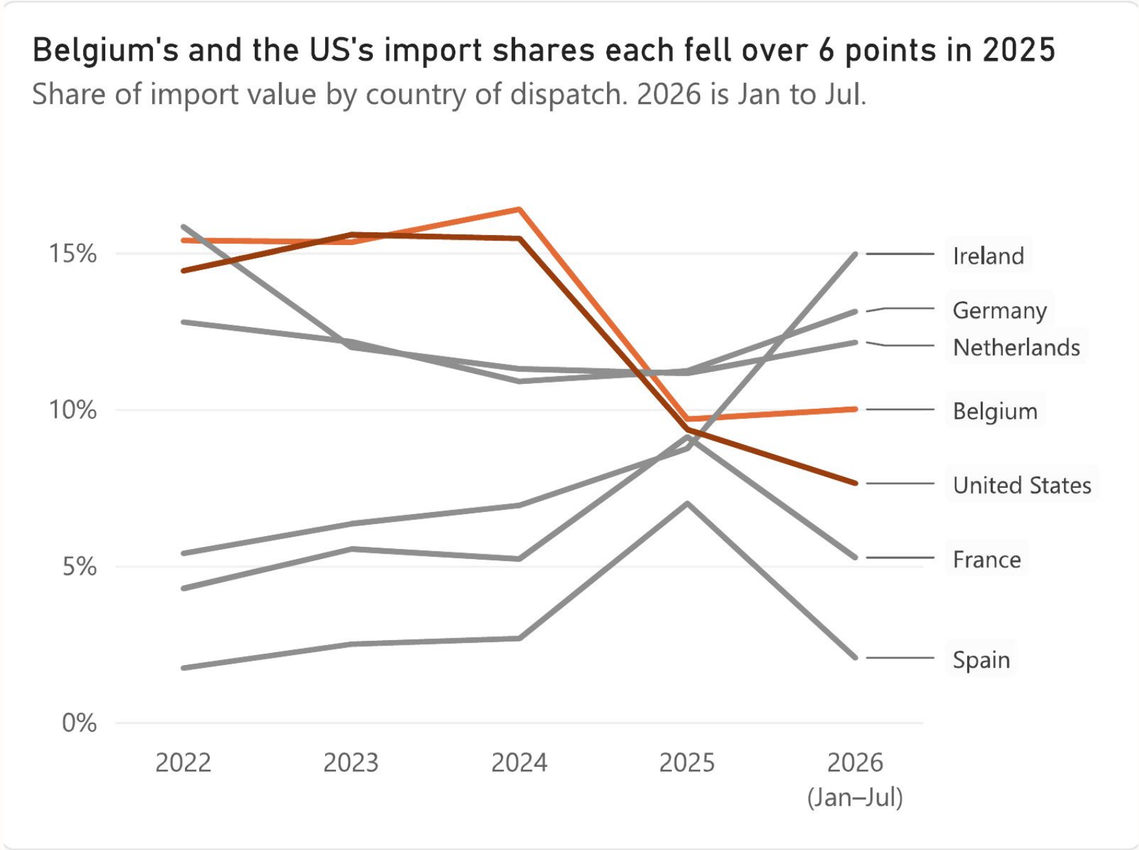
The gap

- The gap has widened every year since 2023, so imports now outweigh exports.
- Imports fell sharply in 2023, then rose in 2024 and 2025. Exports fell every year.
- Without eight unusually large Israel import months (£1.02bn), the gap still closes in 2023, but by less.



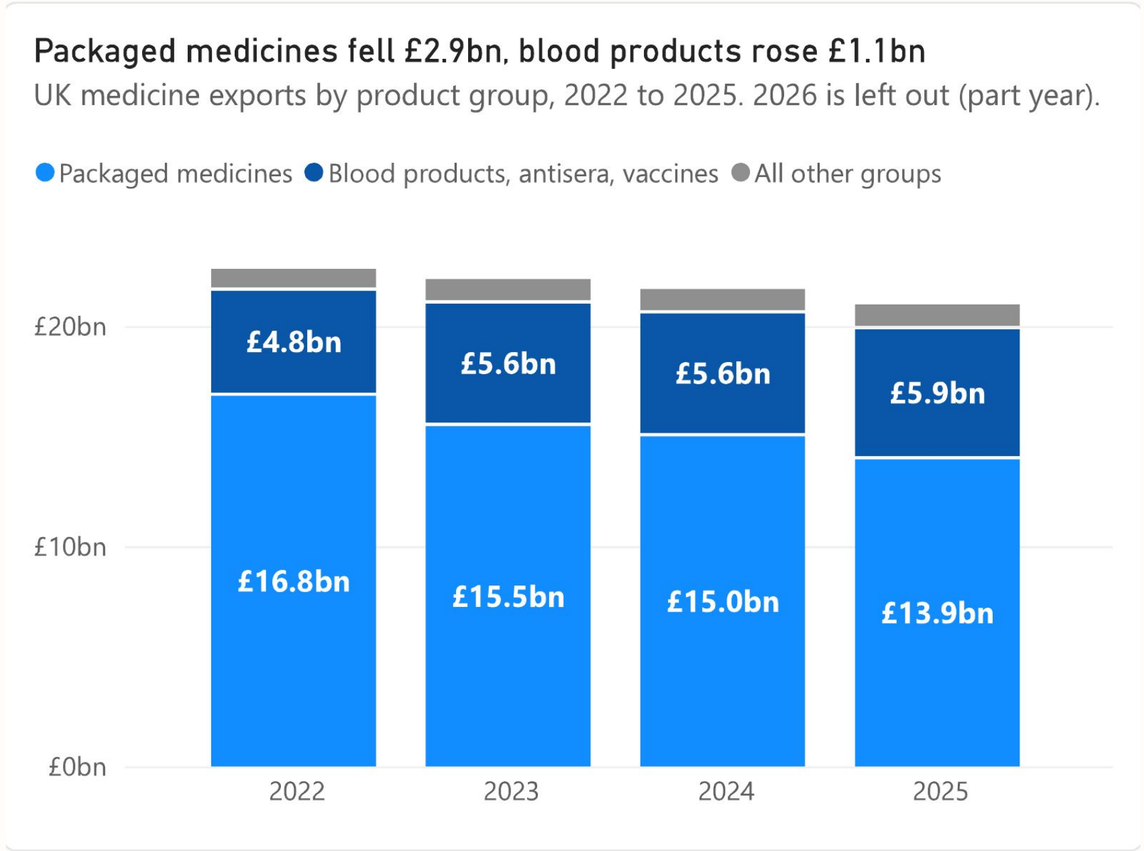
The buyers

- The US, Belgium and Germany took 47% of export value over the whole period.
- The 2023 swing did not last: the US was back to 23% in 2024, and Germany has risen every year since.
- Customs data shows the shares, not the reasons behind the 2023 swing.



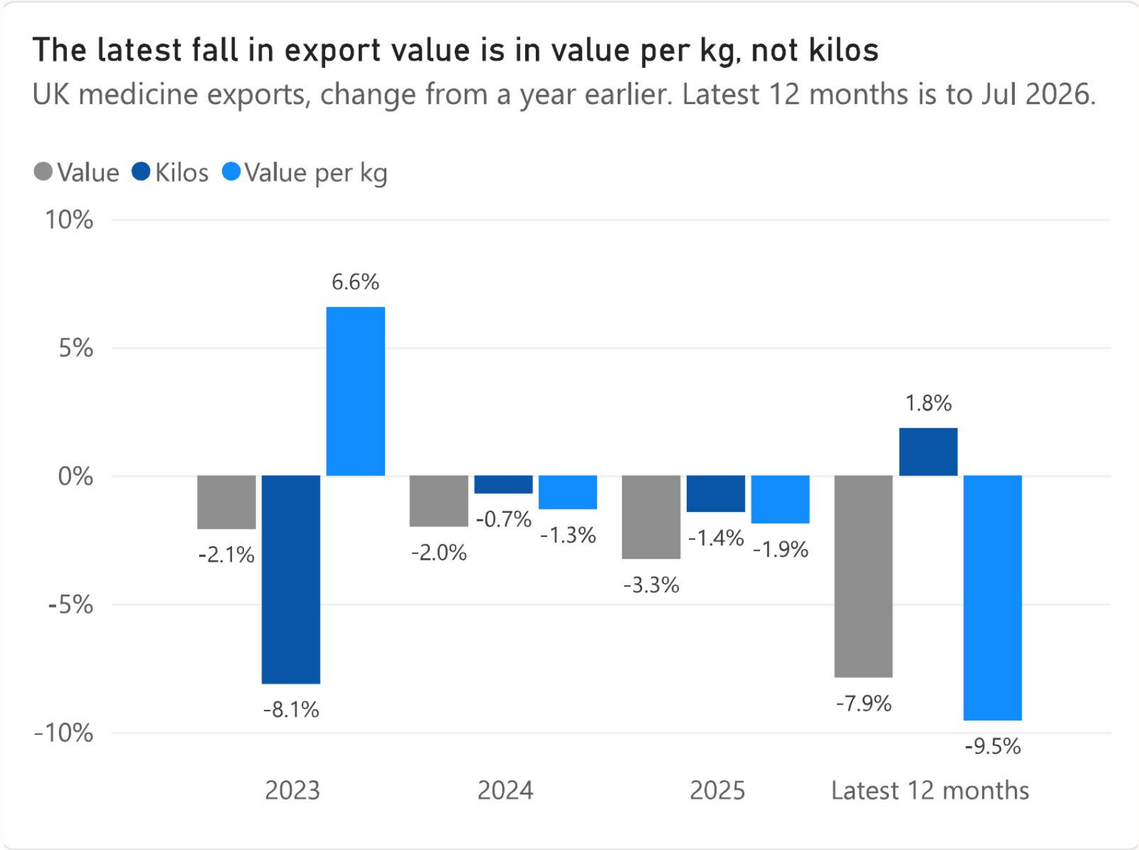
The suppliers

- Over the period, Belgium, the US, the Netherlands and Germany each sent 12–14% of imports.
- In 2025 France and Spain rose as Belgium and the US fell, then dropped back in 2026.
- These are countries of dispatch, not makers. 2026 is January to July only.



The products

- Packaged medicines, about 70% of export value, fell every year, from £16.8bn in 2022 to £13.9bn in 2025.
- The group's trade also swung from a £0.7bn surplus in 2024 to a £1.6bn deficit in 2025.
- Blood products, antisera and vaccines rose from £4.8bn in 2022 to £5.9bn in 2025.



Value per kg

- In the latest 12 months, export value fell 7.9% while kilos rose 1.8%.
- So value per kg, which is value divided by weight, fell 9.5%.
- It is not a price, because it also moves with the mix of medicines.

Limitations

Causes
Customs data shows what moved, not why.

Over time
Values are not adjusted for inflation. 2026 is January to July, and may be revised.

Imports
Countries are countries of dispatch, and values include shipping and insurance.

Israel months
Eight unusually large import months (£1.02bn) change the 2022–23 figures, not the direction.

Recommendations

01 Packaged medicines

Look here first. Next step: split them by product and by buyer.

02 Value per kg

Find out why before acting. Next step: compare each product’s export value with its weight sold.

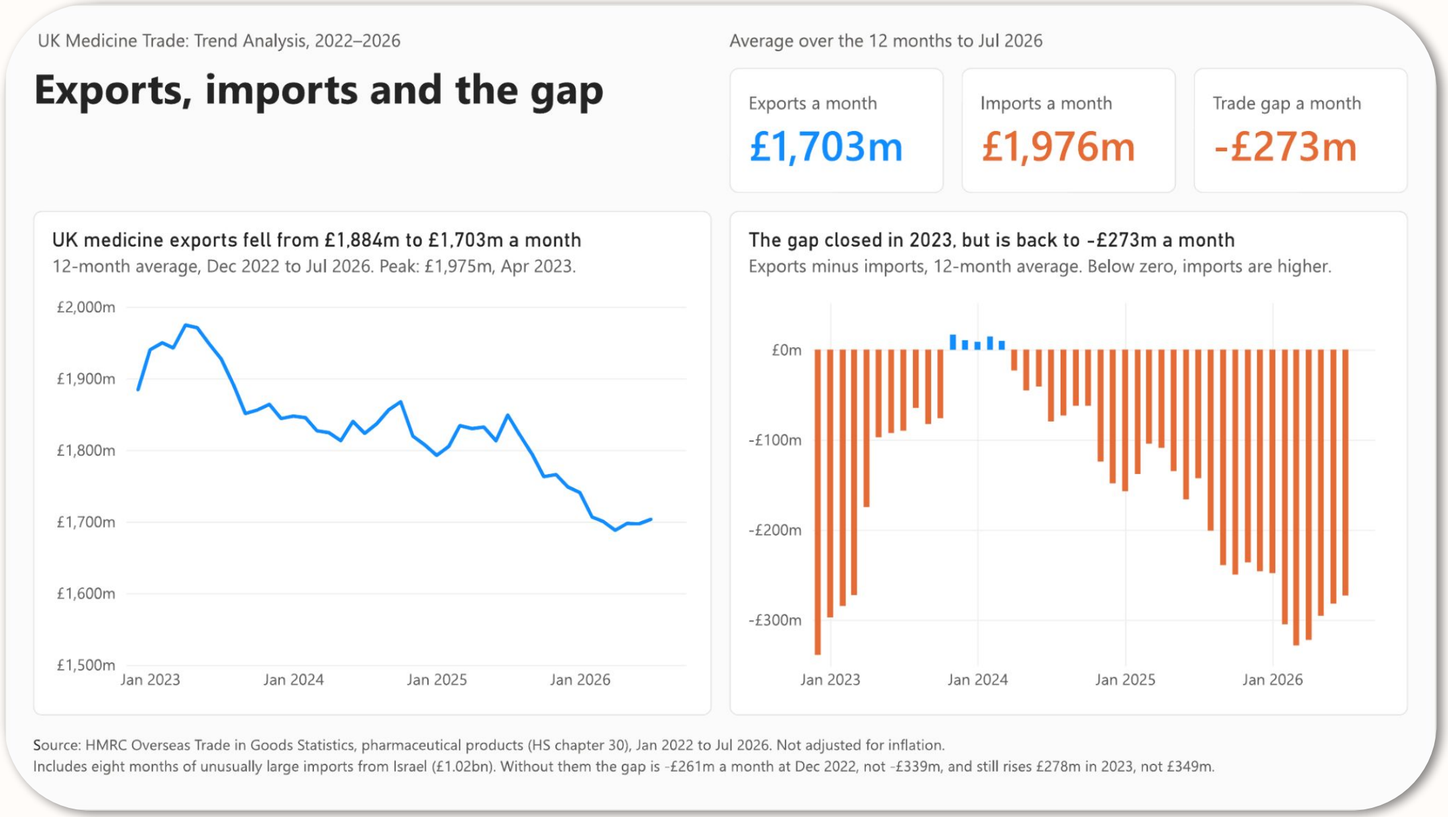
03 Main buyers and suppliers

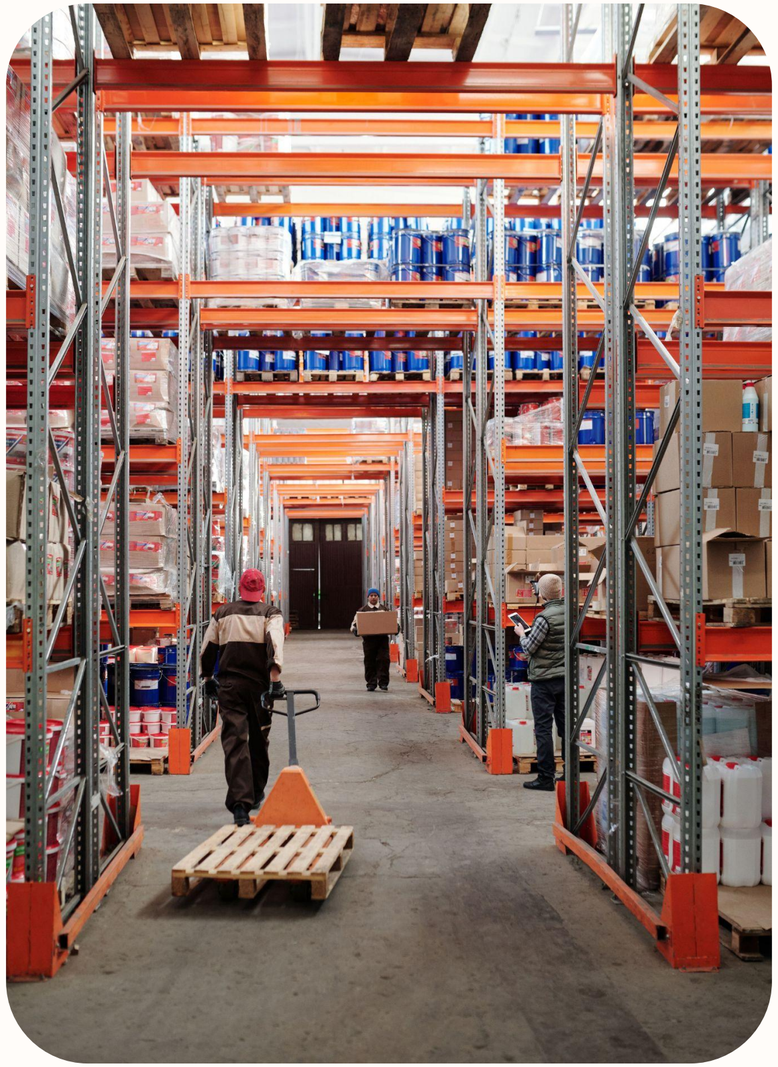
Keep them in view. Next step: track each country’s share every quarter.

Explore the dashboard

Open the Power BI file, or read the PDF copy, on GitHub.

github.com/EmanuelC-UK/uk-medicine-trade-analysis





Thank you

Emanuel Cunha

Data Analyst

emanuel.cunha.uk@gmail.com

linkedin.com/in/emanuel-cunha-uk

github.com/EmanuelC-UK

Credits

Slide 1: Monochrome close-up of assorted blister packs with pills, highlighting pharmaceutical packaging.
Photo by freestocks.org from Pexels: https://www.pexels.com/photo/gray-blister-pack-140123/

Slide 2: Airbus A330 being loaded with cargo on an airport runway, showcasing transportation logistics.
Photo by Teresa Jang from Pexels: https://www.pexels.com/photo/a-large-airplane-with-luggage-being-loaded-onto-it-27490332/

Slide 3: Aerial shot of a busy container port in Scotland with cranes and colorful cargo containers.
Photo by Ollie Craig from Pexels: https://www.pexels.com/photo/an-aerial-photography-of-cargo-containers-near-the-ocean-7519262/

Slide 3: Healthcare worker in scrubs organizing medication in a medical facility.
Photo by RDNE Stock project from Pexels: https://www.pexels.com/photo/medical-practitioner-getting-medicine-from-shelf-6129585/

Slide 15: Workers arrange inventory on shelves in a large industrial warehouse.
Photo by Tiger Lily from Pexels: https://www.pexels.com/photo/men-working-in-factory-warehouse-4483772/

Template: Minimalist White by SlidesCarnival (slidescarnival.com), adapted for this deck.
Licensed under CC BY 4.0: https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/